UPSC PLAN OF EXAMINATION

26/07/25

UPSC CSE –

Union Public Service Commission Civil Services Examination

Two Stages –

1. Preliminary Examination – Objective Type for selection in Main exam

2. Main Examination – Written and Interview / Personality Test for selection in various Services and Post.

NOTE

1. Qualifying list of Candidates for CSE (Main)-

Minimum 33% in General Studies Paper II and I (Total qualifying marks) (Determined)

2. Negative Marking –

i) For wrong answers $\frac{1}{3}$ (0.33) marks of question deducted

ii) More than one answer → Wrong answer → Penalty.

iii) Question left blank (No Penalty)

SCHEME AND SUBJECTS -

A) PRELIMINARY EXAMINATION - (Qualifying, Not Merit)

Two Compulsory Papers of 200 Marks Each.

i) Paper - I (General Studies I) (200 Marks)
Duration - 2 Hours

Total - 100 Questions

→ Clear competitive Cut-off to qualify

Cut off - (2021) Cut off (2024)

General - 87.54 87.98

Usual range - 90-120

Solve questions approx - 70-85 Questions

Marks per question → 2 Negative mark - 0.66

ii) Paper - II CSAT (Civil Services Aptitude Test) - 200 Marks

Total Questions - 80 questions (Duration - 2 Hours)

→ 33% of Total (200 Marks) - 66 Marks (Cut-off)

Solve Questions approx - 30+ questions Correctly

Marks per question → 2.5 Negative mark - 0.83

B) MAIN EXAMINATION -

Written Paper, 9 Exams (one interview)

Qualifying Papers -

(Duration - 3 Hours) Paper - A (Indian languages) (300 Marks)

(one of languages selected)

(Hindi - ~~Devnagri~~) (Devanagari))

Matriculation or equivalent standard

Cut-off - 25% Marks → 75 Marks (of 300 Marks)

No minimum or fixed Number of questions

(Duration - 3 Hours) Paper - B (English) (300 Marks)

(English (Roman))

Matriculation or equivalent standard

Cut-off - 25% Marks → 75 Marks

(No fix ~~minimum~~ minimum number of questions)

Papers to be Counted for Merit -

Minimum Marks → 10% of → 25 Marks
250 Marks

Also Clear Cut-off by Official Criteria
(determined each year)

(Duration - 3 Hours for each paper)

Interview / personality Test - 25-30 Minutes

Paper-I (250 Marks)

Essay (Same for all papers)

Paper-II

General Studies-I

Indian Heritage and Culture, History and Geography of the world and Society

Paper-III

General - Studies - II

Governance, Constitution, Polity, Social justice and International relations

Paper-IV

General Studies-III

Technology, Economic development, Bio-diversity Environment, Security and disaster management

Paper-V

General Studies-IV

Ethics, Integrity and Aptitude

Paper-VI

Optional Subject - Paper-1

Paper-VII

Optional Subject - Paper-2

Sub (Total) (Written Test) 1750 Marks

Personality Test 275 Marks

Grand Total 2025 Marks

Imp Paper A and B (Languages) (Not for Merit)

Optional Subjects for Main Examination-

i) Agriculture
ii) Animal Husbandry and Veterinary Sciences
iii) Anthropology
iv) Botany
v) Chemistry
vi) Civil Engineering
vii) Commerce and Accountancy
viii) Economics
ix) Electrical Engineering
x) Geography
xi) Geology
xii) History
xiii) Law
xiv) Management
xv) Mathematics
xvi) Mechanical Engineering
xvii) Medical Science
xviii) Philosophy
xix) Physics
xx) Political Science and International Relations
xxi) Psycology
xxii) Public Administration
xxiii) Sociology
xxiv) Statistics
xxv) Zoology
xxvi) Literature in one of the following languages:

Assamese, Bengali, Bodo, Dogri, Gujarati, Hindi, Kannada, Kashmiri, Konkani, Maithili, Malyalam,

Manipuri, Marathi, Nepali, Odia, Punjabi, Sanskrit, Santhali, Sindhi, Tamil, Telugu, Urdu and English

SYLLABI FOR THE EXAMINATION

PART-A PRELIMINARY EXAMINATION

Paper-I (200 Marks)

- Current events of National and International importance.
- History of India and Indian National Movement.
- Indian and World geography - Physical, Social, Economic Geography of India and the World.
- Indian Polity and Governance - Constitution, Political System, Panchayati Raj, Public Policy, Rights, Issues etc.
- Economic and Social development - Sustainable development, Poverty, Inclusion, demographics, Social Sector initiatives, etc.
- General issues on Environmental ecology, Bio-diversity and climate change - that do not require subject specialization

General Science

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Paper - II (200 Marks)

- Comprehension
- Interpersonal skills including communication skills
- Logical reasoning and analytical abilities
- Decision making and problem solving
- General mental ability
- Basic numeracy (numbers and their relations, order of magnitude etc) (Class X level), Data interpretation (charts, graphs, tables, data sufficiency etc - Class X level)

PART B - MAIN EXAMINATION

QUALIFYING PAPERS ON INDIAN LANGUAGES AND ENGLISH -

Read and understand serious discursive prose and to express ideas creatively and correctly, in English and Indian language concerned.

The pattern of questions would be broadly

as follows -

i) Comprehension of given passages

ii) Precis writing

iii) Usage and vocabulary

iv) Short Essays

Indian languages :-

Same as above

v) Translation from English to the language and vice-versa.

Note - Candidates will have to answer English and Indian languages papers in English and the respective indian language (except when the translation is involved)

MERIT PAPERS

PAPER - I

Essay - Write essays on multiple topics.

Subject of essay → arrange ideas in orderly fashion, write concisely.

Credit → effective and exact expression

2 Essay → Section A and B → 125 Marks Each

→ 4 options in Each section → 1 to be written

General Syllabus -

Issues → Social, Economical, political, Cultural, Philosophical aspects → National and International

General Structure for Essay -

Word limit - 1000 - 1200

PESTEL analysis → Political, Economic, Sociological, Technological, legal, Environmental analysis

→ A Clear Introduction

→ Body with well-developed paragraphs → Supportive, Critical or narrative

Start → aptly phrased narrative paragraph which describe the topic in some detail

Middle → Supportive paragraph containing positive

fact / ideas on the topic.

Critical or narrative paragraph at last -

looks good but can be placed at top for some topics

Conclusion -

FREEDOES -

- Facts and statistics
- Reasons
- Examples
- Quotes
- Opinions
- Experiences
- Senses

& Positive outlook → Silver lining in the clouds

& Clear and concise

Paper - II

General Studies - I : Indian Heritage and culture, History and Geography of the world and society

Word limit → 200 words per question

General guidelines and exam patterns for GS-I to IV

* GS paper IV (Ethics) → 150, 250, 300 as word limits

99% → opinion based questions

* Best to write answer in paragraphs

* Write sentences that are short.

* Use a semicolon (;) to separate a sentences into clauses with each clause addressing a related but different idea or argument.

Word Count	Marks
150 words	10 marks
220 - 225 words	15 marks
300 marks (250-300 Marks)	20 marks

* GS papers - limit of 200 words per question or 150 words or 250 words
↓
Except GS-paper IV (Ethics) (Paper-V)

[Visit Page-14 for separate description]

Optional Subjects -

Mostly - 150 word limits {Short Note Section}

* Rest questions → No word limit specified

Word count → Vary from 150-350

No negative marking in mains
For GS above two formats - they can happen

* Usually 20 questions per paper are asked
↳ (12.5 Marks each question)

1.
2. in GS (General Studies) 10 questions → 150 words → 10 marks, rest 10 → 15 marks → 250 words
3. they format can be used

Language Exam Pattern

100 Marks → Essay Questions

60 Marks → Reading Comprehension questions

60 Marks → Precis writing

40 Marks → Translation based questions

40 Marks → Grammar based questions

Interview Round

Questions Range from -

1. Personal details → Interests, Hobbies, Work, education,

2. Current Affairs → Issues of national and international importance

3. Socio-Economic issues → currently taking place in the country or in homeplace

4 Situational based → assess decision making capabilities

5. Opinion-based → Analytical skills and moral integrity

Detailed GS papers No. of Questions, word limit and marks –

1. Paper-II (GS-I)

20 Questions → (10 Marks and 20 Marks)

→ 10 Questions → 150 words → 10 Marks (Ten)

→ 10 Questions → 250 words → 10 Marks (Twenty)

Total – 250 Marks

2. Paper-III (GS-II)

Same as Paper-II (GS-I)

3. Paper-IV (GS-III)

Same as paper-II (GS-I)

4. Paper-V (GS-IV)

12 Questions

Section – A – 6 Questions – Part (a) (b) 150 words

(10 Marks) (each part like (a) (b) (c))

→ one Question has 3 Parts

Total – 130 Marks

Section-B – 6 Questions – 250 words – 20 Marks

Total – 150 Marks

Grand Total – 250 Marks

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IMPORTANT NOTE

* 20 Questions → GS Paper I to III → 12.5 Marks each is an older format

* Now it is not used (after 2016)

* Before 2016, this format was used

* From 2017 → 10 question, 10 Marks and 10 question 15 Marks format is used